

THE DEFINITIVE REFERENCE

The Complete Claude Guide

Everything you need to get the most out of Claude.

Written in plain English. No tech talk.

For small business owners, freelancers, and professionals who want AI that actually works.

• Claude Chat &
Desktop

• Cowork — Point & Click
AI

• Every Slash
Command

• MCP
Connections

• Memory &
Automations

• Background
Agents

By Ryan's AI Setup

ryansaisetup.com · ryansaisetup@gmail.com · (929) 501-5423

Your First 10 Minutes with Claude

You've got this. Follow these five steps and you'll have Claude doing real work for you before your coffee gets cold.

1 Download Claude Desktop

30 seconds

⌚ ~30 seconds

Go to **claude.ai/download** in your browser. Click Download for Mac or Windows. Run the installer — it's just like installing any other app. When it's done, you'll see Claude in your Applications folder (Mac) or Start menu (Windows).

💡 Make sure you have a Claude Pro or Max subscription at claude.ai first — that's the paid plan from Anthropic (\$20/month+). The Desktop app is free but needs an active account.

2 Sign In with Your Anthropic Account

⌚ ~1 minute

Open the Claude Desktop app. Click **Sign in with Anthropic**. Enter the same email and password you use at claude.ai. The app will connect and you'll land on the main chat screen — dark background, message box at the bottom.

3 Type Your First Message

⌚ ~2 minutes

Click the text box at the bottom and type this exactly:

"Help me write a professional email declining a meeting"

Press Enter. Watch Claude write you a polished, professional email in about 5 seconds. You can ask it to make it shorter, more casual, or change the reason — just keep talking to it naturally.

4 See What Just Happened

✓ You're an AI user now

⌚ Read this!

Claude didn't search the internet or copy a template. It understood your intent, considered your tone, and generated something original — just for you. This is the core of what makes Claude powerful. **Every response is custom-written for your exact request.**

💡 The more specific you are, the better Claude gets. Try adding: "I'm a real estate agent and this is a client who wants me to attend a 2-hour Saturday meeting." Watch the email transform.

 ~5 minutes

In the Claude Desktop app, look for the **Cowork tab** (top of the left panel, next to "Chat"). Click it. You'll see a panel asking you to **select a working folder** — click "Choose Folder" and pick your Documents folder (or any folder with files). Then type:

"Summarize all the documents in this folder and give me a one-paragraph overview of each one"

Claude will actually open your files, read them, and give you summaries. This isn't magic — it's AI with permission to access your computer. This is what makes Claude different from every other AI tool you've tried.



You did it! In 10 minutes you've learned the two core ways to use Claude: **Chat** for quick tasks, **Cowork** for working with your actual files. The rest of this guide goes deeper on every feature — but you now have everything you need to start saving time today.

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What Is Claude?

Claude is an AI assistant built by Anthropic. Unlike ChatGPT, Claude was designed from the ground up to be helpful, safe, and honest. But the real difference isn't the personality — it's **what you can do with it**.

Claude isn't just a chatbot you talk to in a browser. When set up properly, Claude can:

- Read and write your files, documents, and code
- Connect to your email, calendar, social media, and other tools
- Remember your preferences, business context, and past conversations
- Run automations and scheduled tasks on your behalf
- Deploy background agents that work while you do other things

Think of it like hiring a very smart assistant who works 24/7, never forgets anything, and gets better the more you use them.

 PRO TIP

Claude Pro (\$20/month paid to Anthropic) gives you enough usage for a full workday of AI assistance. It's the plan I recommend for most people. Claude Max (\$100/month) is for power users who want unlimited usage and priority access to the latest models.

Why Claude Over Other AI Tools?

Feature	Claude Pro/Max	ChatGPT	Gemini
Long documents	✓ Up to 200K tokens	Limited	Limited
File access (Cowork)	✓ Full desktop access	Partial	Partial
Memory system	✓ CLAUDE.md file	Basic	Basic
MCP connections	✓ Full support	Limited	✗
Background agents	✓ Full agent mode	Limited	Limited

The Three Things Claude Can Do

- **Think** — Answer questions, brainstorm ideas, analyze information, write content
- **Do** — Access your files, connect to tools, run tasks on your computer (via Cowork or Claude Code)
- **Remember** — Learn your preferences, business context, and working style over time

Chat vs. Code vs. Cowork

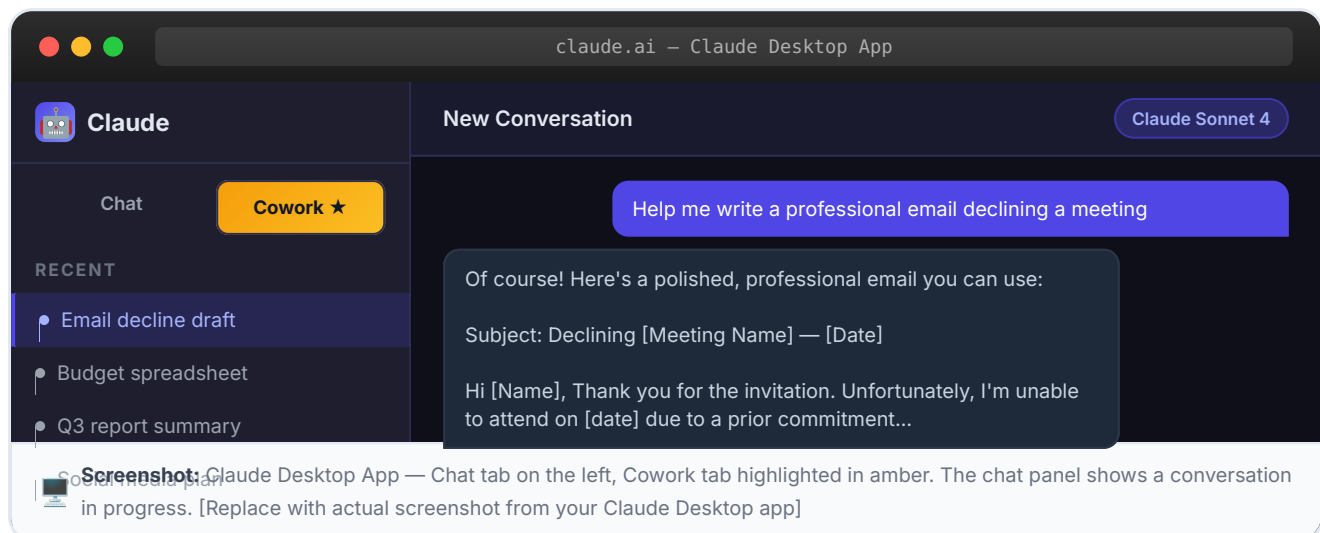
Claude comes in three flavors. Each one is the same AI, but with different tools available. Here's when to use each — and why it matters.

Claude Chat (claude.ai)

The simplest way to use Claude. Open a browser, type a message, get a response. Great for quick questions, brainstorming, writing drafts, and research.

Best for: Quick questions, writing help, brainstorming, summarizing documents you paste in, general conversation.

Limitations: Can't access your files, tools, or computer. No automations. Conversations don't carry context between sessions (unless you use Projects).



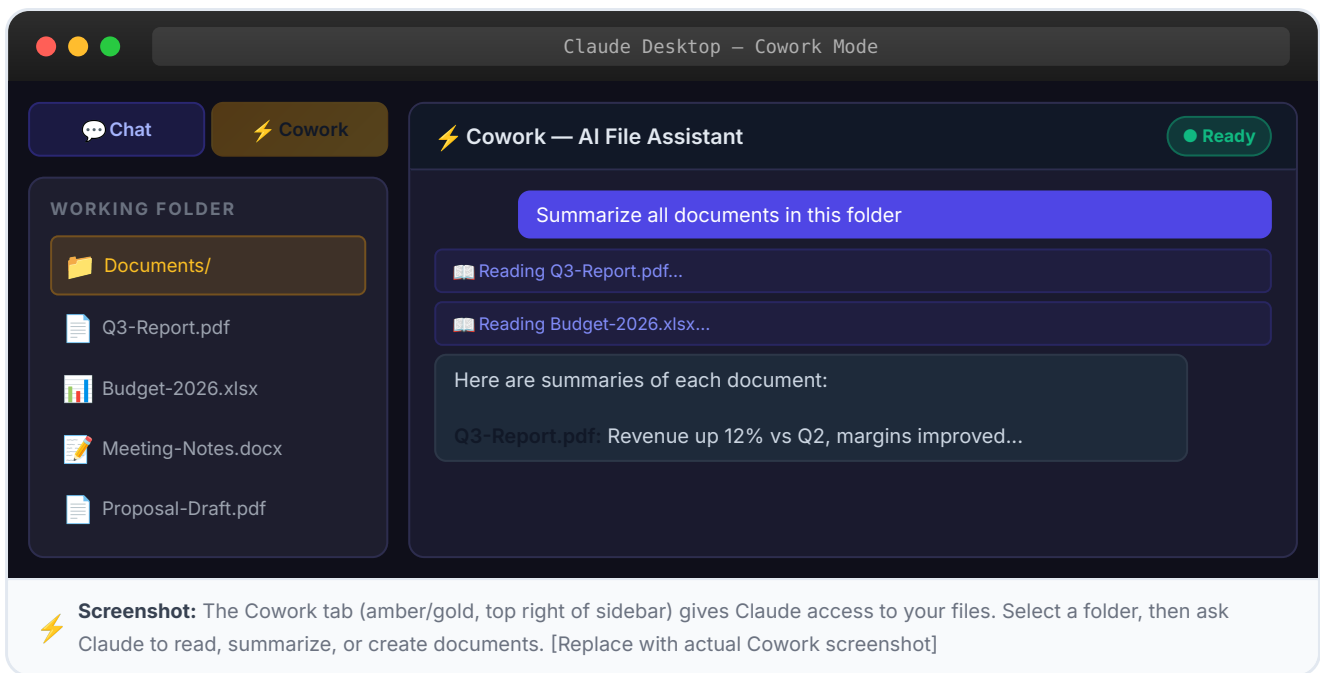
Cowork (Desktop App) Launched Jan 2026

Cowork is the visual, point-and-click version of Claude Code. It runs inside the Claude Desktop App and gives you all the same power — but without needing to touch a terminal. **For most non-technical users, this is where you'll spend most of your time.**

What Cowork can do:

- Create real documents — Excel spreadsheets (.xlsx), PowerPoint presentations (.pptx), Word documents (.docx), and PDFs. These aren't just text — they're fully formatted, professional files you can open and edit.
- Work with your files — select a folder from your computer and Cowork can read, organize, rename, and manage everything in it.
- Connect to your tools — email, calendar, Slack, Notion, Google Drive, and more. Cowork has a connectors panel where you can browse and connect services with a few clicks.
- Run scheduled tasks — set up automations that run on a timer, like "every morning at 8am, summarize my unread emails."

- Browse the web — Cowork can search the internet, read web pages, and pull in information for you.
- Use plugins — install add-ons that give Claude new abilities.



How to Open Cowork

Open the Claude Desktop App on your Mac or Windows PC. Click the **Cowork tab** (top of the left panel — it glows amber/gold). Select a folder to work in, and start chatting.

Real Examples of What to Ask Cowork

```
"Create a monthly budget spreadsheet with formulas for income and expenses"
"Make a 10-slide pitch deck for my business"
"Read all the PDFs in my Downloads folder and summarize each one"
"Draft a professional proposal letter and save it as a Word doc"
"Check my Gmail and tell me if anything urgent came in today"
```

💡 PRO TIP

Cowork is the best starting point for anyone who isn't comfortable with a terminal. You get the same AI power as Claude Code, just with a friendlier interface. Once you're comfortable, you can explore Claude Code for more advanced tasks.

Claude Code (Terminal)

The power-user tool. Runs in your terminal (command line) and can read/write files, run code, connect to tools, and deploy background agents. This is what I install during the Claude AI Setup service.

Best for: File management, coding, connecting to tools (email, calendar, etc.), deploying agents, building automations, any task that requires Claude to actually DO something on your computer.

How to open it: Open your terminal and type `claude`

Which One Should You Use?

Quick question or brainstorm?

→ [Claude Chat](#)

Need documents, spreadsheets, or file management?

→ [Cowork](#)

Want to connect email, calendar, or other tools?

→ [Cowork or Claude Code](#)

Building something technical or writing code?

→ [Claude Code](#)

Setting up automations?

→ [Either \(Cowork = simple, Code = complex\)](#)

Most people use all three depending on the situation. That's totally normal.

Getting Started with Claude Code

Claude Code runs in your terminal. It's the power-user version of Claude that can take real actions on your computer. Here's how to get going.

Opening Claude Code

Open your terminal (Mac: press `⌘` + Space, type "Terminal", press Enter) and type:

```
claude
# Press Enter. Claude will start and you can begin chatting.
```

Your First Conversation

Just type naturally. Claude understands plain English. You don't need special syntax or commands. Examples:

```
"Summarize all the PDF files in my Documents folder"
"Write a follow-up email to John about the project deadline"
"Create a spreadsheet tracking my monthly expenses"
"What meetings do I have tomorrow?" (if calendar is connected)
```

Understanding Permissions

When Claude needs to read a file, run a command, or take an action, it will ask for your permission first. You'll see a prompt — press **Tab** or **Enter** to approve, or **Escape** to cancel. This keeps you in control.

PRO TIP

Claude remembers your permission preferences. After you approve something a few times, it stops asking. You can always review permissions with the `/permissions` command.

The First Week: What to Try



Day 1: Email tasks

- Draft a follow-up email to [person] about [topic]
- Write a thank-you note to my client Sarah
- Create an email template for new client onboarding



Day 2: Document tasks

- Read all the PDFs in my Downloads folder and give me a summary
- Create a project proposal for [client name]
- Turn these notes into a formatted report



Day 3: Planning tasks

- Create a content calendar for the next month
- Build a simple CRM spreadsheet for tracking leads
- Make a checklist for my weekly review process

Every Slash Command Explained

Type `/` in Claude Code to see all available commands. Here are the most useful ones, organized by what they do.

Terminal — Claude Code

/

AVAILABLE COMMANDS — TYPE TO FILTER

`/clear`

Start a fresh conversation. Use when switching tasks.

`/compact`

Compress conversation to free up memory. Add focus instructions.

`/memory`

Edit Claude's memory files (CLAUDE.md).

`/mcp`

Manage connections to external tools (email, calendar...).

`/model`

Switch between AI models (Sonnet / Opus).

 **Screenshot:** Type / in Claude Code to see the command dropdown. Commands are searchable — just keep typing to filter.

[Replace with actual terminal screenshot]

Session Management

`/clear`

Session

Start a fresh conversation. Use this when switching to a new task.

`/compact`

Session

Compress the current conversation to free up memory. Add focus instructions like:
Example: `/compact keep the project requirements`

`/resume`

Session

Pick up a previous conversation right where you left off.

`/context`

Session

See how much memory the conversation is using. If it's high, use `/compact`.

`/branch`

Session

Create a copy of the conversation so you can try something different without losing the original.

`/rename`

Session

Give the conversation a name so you can find it later.

/rewind

Session

Go back to an earlier point in the conversation. Great for undoing mistakes.

/export

Session

Save the entire conversation as a text file. Useful for record-keeping.

/copy

Session

Copy the last response to your clipboard.

Model & Performance

`/model`

Performance

Switch between AI models. Sonnet for everyday tasks, Opus for complex problems.

`/effort`

Performance

Control how deeply Claude thinks. Use low for quick answers, high for important work.

Options: `/effort low` | `/effort medium` | `/effort high` | `/effort max`

`/fast`

Performance

Toggle fast mode for quicker responses on simple tasks.

Tools & Configuration

`/mcp`

Tools

Manage connections to external tools (email, calendar, etc.).

`/memory`

Tools

Edit Claude's memory files — how it remembers your preferences.

`/permissions`

Tools

View or change what Claude is allowed to do.

`/config`

Tools

Open settings — theme, model, output style.

`/skills`

Tools

List all available skills Claude can use.

`/init`

Tools

Set up a new project with a CLAUDE.md file.

`/plugin`

Tools

Install or manage plugins that add new capabilities.

Power Features

`/batch`

Power

Make large-scale changes across many files in parallel.

Example: `/batch update all error messages to be more descriptive`

`/loop`

Power

Run a task repeatedly on a schedule.

Example: `/loop 5m check if the website is still up`

`/schedule`

Power

Create tasks that run automatically on a schedule.

`/security-review`

Power

Scan your changes for security vulnerabilities.

`/voice`

Power

Talk to Claude instead of typing. Great for brainstorming on the go.

Quick Reference

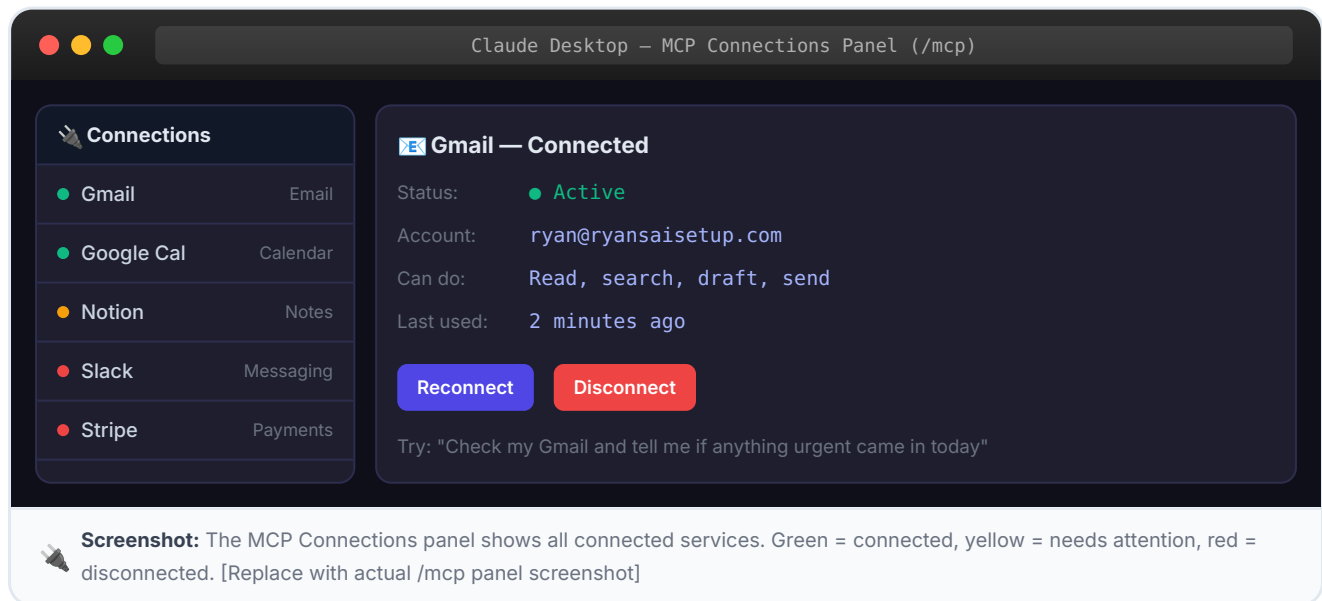
```
/help # See all available commands
/cost # Check your token usage and cost
/usage # View your plan limits
/doctor # Diagnose installation issues
/stats # View your usage history and streaks
/debug # Troubleshoot issues with current session
/diff # View all uncommitted changes visually
/simplify # Review recent changes and clean up
```

Connecting Your Tools (MCP)

MCP stands for Model Context Protocol. It's how Claude talks to external tools and services. Think of each MCP connection as a "plug" that lets Claude access a specific app.

What You Can Connect

- **Email:** Gmail, Outlook — Claude can read, search, and draft emails
- **Calendar:** Google Calendar, Outlook — view events, check availability, create meetings
- **Files:** Google Drive, local files — read, write, organize documents
- **Notes:** Notion — read and update pages and databases
- **Messaging:** Slack — read and send messages
- **Social Media:** LinkedIn, Instagram, X — schedule posts, track engagement
- **Business Tools:** Stripe, CRMs, project management tools



How to Set Up a Connection

In Claude Code, type:

```
/mcp
# Follow the prompts to add a new server.
# Pattern: select service → authenticate → test connection
```

In Cowork (desktop app), click the connectors panel, search for the service, click Connect, and follow the authentication flow.

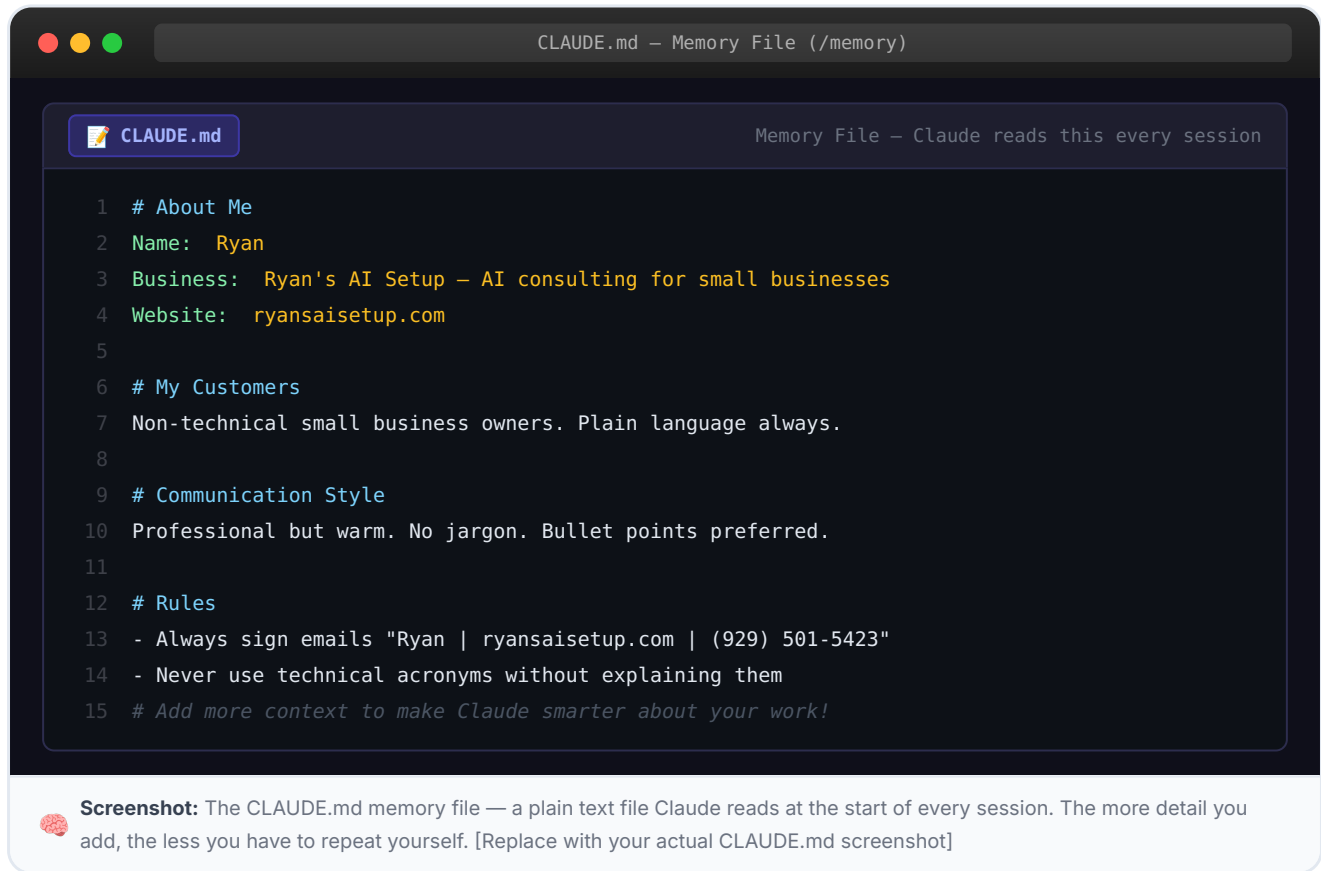
Start with email and calendar — they're the connections that make Claude immediately useful in your daily life. Once those are connected, you can ask: "What meetings do I have tomorrow?" or "Did I get any emails from [client] this week?"

Claude's Memory System

Claude's memory is powered by a file called `CLAUDE.md`. This is a simple text file that tells Claude about you, your business, and your preferences. The better this file, the more useful Claude becomes.

What to Put in Your CLAUDE.md

- Your name, role, and business description
- Who your customers are
- Your communication style (formal? casual? somewhere in between?)
- Key contacts and their roles
- How you like emails drafted, reports formatted, etc.
- Rules — things Claude should always or never do
- Your preferred tools and accounts



The screenshot shows a code editor window titled "CLAUDE.md - Memory File (/memory)". The editor displays the content of the CLAUDE.md file, which is a plain text file. The file contains the following text:

```
1 # About Me
2 Name: Ryan
3 Business: Ryan's AI Setup - AI consulting for small businesses
4 Website: ryansaisetup.com
5
6 # My Customers
7 Non-technical small business owners. Plain language always.
8
9 # Communication Style
10 Professional but warm. No jargon. Bullet points preferred.
11
12 # Rules
13 - Always sign emails "Ryan | ryansaisetup.com | (929) 501-5423"
14 - Never use technical acronyms without explaining them
15 # Add more context to make Claude smarter about your work!
```

Below the code editor, there is a red brain icon and a text box containing the following text:

Screenshot: The CLAUDE.md memory file — a plain text file Claude reads at the start of every session. The more detail you add, the less you have to repeat yourself. [Replace with your actual CLAUDE.md screenshot]

How to Edit It

```
/memory
# This opens your memory files for editing.
```

You can also ask Claude directly: "Add to your memory that I prefer bullet points in reports" — and it will update the file for you.

PRO TIP

The more context you put in CLAUDE.md, the less you have to repeat yourself. Spend 15 minutes making this file detailed — it pays off every single day. Think of it like your AI assistant's onboarding document.

Sample CLAUDE.md Template

Here's a starting template you can copy and customize:

```
# About Me
Name: [Your Name]
Business: [Your business name and what you do]
Website: [Your website]

# My Customers
[Describe who you serve]

# Communication Style
[How formal? What tone? Length preference?]

# Key Contacts
- [Name]: [Role and relationship]

# Rules
- Always include my contact info in emails
- [Add your own rules here]
```

Deploying Agents

Agents are one of Claude's most powerful features. An agent is essentially a mini version of Claude that you send off to do a specific task in the background while you keep working.

How Agents Work

When you ask Claude to do something complex, it can spawn agents — separate AI workers that each handle a piece of the task. For example, if you say "review all the files in this project," Claude might spawn 5 agents that each review different files simultaneously.

💡 Think of agents like hiring a temp agency. Instead of doing all the work yourself (or asking Claude one thing at a time), you describe the full project and Claude assembles a team of AI workers to handle it in parallel — finishing in a fraction of the time.

The /batch Command

The most direct way to use agents. Give it an instruction and it will:

1. Research what needs to be done
2. Break the work into 5–30 independent pieces
3. Show you the plan for approval
4. Spawn one agent per piece, all working in parallel
5. Each agent does its work, tests it, and reports back

```
/batch update all customer-facing error messages to be friendlier
# Claude finds every error message, assigns each file to an agent,
# and they all rewrite the messages simultaneously.
```

Real Business Examples



File & Document Processing

- /batch read every PDF in my Documents folder and create a summary spreadsheet
- /batch rename all my photo files to include the date and description
- /batch convert all .docx files in this folder to PDF format



Communication

- /batch draft follow-up emails for each lead in my CRM spreadsheet
- /batch write personalized thank-you notes for the 20 clients on this list

→ /batch create individual meeting summaries from these 10 transcript files



Content Creation

→ /batch create 30 days of social media posts from these blog posts

→ /batch write product descriptions for each item in this catalog spreadsheet

→ /batch translate these 15 documents from English to Spanish

PRO TIP

Always review the plan before approving a /batch job. Claude will show you exactly what it plans to do — read it carefully, especially when it involves editing or deleting files. You can always say "looks good" to proceed or "cancel" to stop.

Automations and Scheduled Tasks

Automations are tasks that run on a schedule without you lifting a finger. This is where AI goes from "helpful" to "essential."

Setting Up a Scheduled Task

```
/schedule  
# Claude will walk you through setting up the task conversationally.  
# Just describe what you want in plain English.
```

Examples of what to say:

```
"Every weekday at 8am, summarize my unread emails"  
"Every Friday at 5pm, compile a summary of what I worked on this week"  
"Every Monday morning, check my calendar and prepare briefings for each meeting"  
"Every day at 9pm, draft social media posts for tomorrow"
```

Automation Ideas by Profession



Small Business Owner

- Morning email digest — summarize overnight emails every day at 8am
- Invoice reminders — check for unpaid invoices every Monday
- Social media scheduling — draft tomorrow's posts every evening at 9pm
- Weekly revenue summary — compile this week's numbers every Friday at 4pm



Real Estate Agent

- New listing alerts — scan for new properties matching your criteria daily
- Follow-up reminders — check leads who haven't heard from you in 7 days
- Open house prep — create showing sheets 24 hours before each listing
- Market report generation — compile neighborhood data every Sunday



Freelancer / Consultant

- Time tracking summaries — compile billable hours at end of each day
- Invoice generation — create invoices for completed work every Monday
- Client follow-ups — check for unanswered client emails every morning

- Project status updates — draft weekly progress reports every Thursday



Law Firm / Professional Services

- Case file summaries — summarize new documents added to case folders daily
- Deadline tracking — alert you to upcoming court dates and filing deadlines
- Document preparation — draft standard forms from intake information
- Client communication logs — compile all client interactions weekly

PRO TIP

Start with ONE automation — the email digest is a great first one. It costs you 5 minutes to set up and saves you 20+ minutes every single morning. Once you see it working, you'll want to automate everything.

Tips, Tricks, and Shortcuts

These are the little things that separate people who get occasional value from Claude and people who save hours every week. Read all of these — they matter.

Keyboard Shortcuts

Escape

Cancel the current response

Tab / Enter

Approve a pending action

Shift + Enter

New line without sending

↑ Arrow

Scroll through previous messages

Ctrl + C

Interrupt a long-running task

Ctrl + L

Clear screen (keeps conversation)

Getting Better Responses

Be Specific

"Write a follow-up email to Sarah about the Q3 report" beats "write an email." The more detail you give, the better the output.

Give Context

"I'm a real estate agent and this client is a first-time buyer" helps Claude tailor its response to your actual situation.

Ask for What You Want

"Keep it under 3 paragraphs" or "make it formal" or "include bullet points." Claude follows instructions precisely.

Iterate Naturally

If the first response isn't perfect, say what to change: "Make it shorter" or "more casual tone." Claude remembers the full context.

Power Moves

/effort max

For your most important tasks — Claude thinks much harder, considers more angles, and gives you its best work. Use for proposals, strategy, anything that really matters.

/voice

Talk to Claude instead of typing — great for brainstorming when you're moving around or don't want to type. Just speak naturally and Claude responds in text.

/export

Save important conversations as text files for your records. Great for keeping a log of decisions, strategies, and important outputs.

Create a skill

Ask Claude to "create a skill" for tasks you do repeatedly — it becomes a one-command shortcut.
Example: "Create a skill called 'weekly-report' that compiles my week's work into a report"

`/compact [focus]`

When conversations get long, Claude can lose focus. Compact with instructions: `/compact focus on the marketing plan`. This frees memory while keeping Claude on track.

PRO TIP

The single biggest ROI move: spend 15 minutes building your CLAUDE.md memory file. Every future conversation gets better automatically. Claude will know your business, your style, and your rules — without you having to repeat yourself every time.

Troubleshooting Common Issues

Most Claude issues are quick to fix. Here's the guide for the most common problems and exactly how to solve them.

? Claude isn't responding

- Check your internet connection
- Run `/doctor` to diagnose installation issues
- Make sure your Claude subscription is active at **claude.ai**
- Try closing and reopening the Claude Desktop app

? Claude forgot what I told it

- Run `/context` — if memory is high, use `/compact` to free space
- Check if your CLAUDE.md file is in place (`/memory`)
- Make sure you haven't used `/clear` (which wipes the conversation)
- If this happens often, put more context in your CLAUDE.md so Claude always has the info

? A tool connection stopped working

- Run `/mcp` and check the status of your connections
- Re-authenticate the connection (permissions sometimes expire after 30-90 days)
- Restart Claude Code and try again
- If it keeps failing, disconnect and reconnect the service from scratch

? My scheduled task didn't run

- Make sure your computer was on and Claude was running at the scheduled time
- Check the task configuration with `/schedule`
- For always-on tasks, consider the Automation Suite or Local AI Command Center
- Automations only run when the Claude app is open (unless you have a server setup)

? Cowork can't find my files

- Click "Choose Folder" again and re-select your working folder
- Make sure you've given Claude permission to access that folder (system settings)
- On Mac: System Settings → Privacy & Security → Files and Folders → allow Claude Desktop

- On Windows: You may need to run Claude Desktop as administrator for some folders

? Responses are slow or cut off

- Switch to a faster model with `/model` → select Claude Sonnet
- Use `/effort low` for quicker responses on simple tasks
- Use `/compact` to reduce conversation length
- Check if Anthropic has any service issues at status.anthropic.com

Need Help?

If you're stuck on anything in this guide, I'm here to help. I offer personal setup calls and troubleshooting sessions — let's get Claude working perfectly for your business.

 **Book a Setup Call**

 **(929) 501-5423**

 **ryansaissetup@gmail.com**

 **ryansaissetup.com**

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